game-changing new data on caste and representation that fundamentally rewires our previous understanding. We see how, after 2013, the BJP has repeatedly confounded opponents and conventional wisdom to achieve electoral blitzkriegs in rural and rurban India, significantly deepening its roots as a political party.[3] This shift, and the mechanisms that brought it about, upended the conventions of Indian politics as we know them.

Chapter 2 establishes the magnitude of the newly acquired rural depth of the BJP. Chapters 3, 4 and 5 explain how and why the party's political advancement came about. The facets of this progress have not truly been understood so far in their entirety. The broad assumption has been that the BJP somehow kept winning elections because of the Narendra Modi phenomenon, his unique brand of personality politics and an appeal to Hindu sentiments alone—and that somehow this would easily fall apart after Modi. Far from it. Modi's appeal is real and tangible, and he has undoubtedly been the primary catalyst for the turnaround. However, the party's surge in the Hindi heartland—in the rural areas and among the lower strata of caste and class—is built on deeper structural shifts undertaken on his watch.

The BJP made fundamental changes at three levels.

One, it radically changed its party structure to become the most socially representative party in UP across Hindu castes. If you leave aside Muslims—and that is an important qualifier—after 2013, the BJP has given positions of power and influence to more social groups and castes than any other party in the state. Chapter 3 shows, with new data, how this happened across several registers: the BJP's political candidates in national and state elections, its state-level office-bearers, district-level presidents, and the ministers it appointed once it had formed a government. The old BJP that was dominated by upper castes is long gone. And the electoral dominance of the new BJP is directly linked to this transformation. While the party retained its urban base, middle-class following and upper-caste support, it significantly expanded its caste representation, becoming the default party of those lower down the social and economic order. Though it had made significant inroads earlier into OBCs under the leadership of its first OBC chief minister